

# AI Ideathon 2026 Official Rules

Welcome to **AI Ideathon 2026: AI for Real World Impact**.

AI Ideathon 2026 is a global online AI hackathon bringing together students, developers, designers, founders, and builders from around the world to create practical AI solutions for meaningful problems.

Please read the following rules carefully before participating.

## 1. Team Structure

- Participants may compete **individually or in teams of up to 4 members**.
- Participants looking for teammates may use the designated **team formation channel on Discord**.
- Each participant may only be part of **one team**.
- Teams must submit their final team information through the official team registration process provided by the organizers.
- Changes to team membership after the submission deadline may require approval from the organizing team.

## 2. Hackathon Theme

The official theme of AI Ideathon 2026 is:

# AI for Real World Impact

Participants are encouraged to identify meaningful problems and build AI solutions that can create measurable value for people, businesses, communities, or society.

Suggested areas include:

### 1. Education and Careers

Create AI solutions that improve learning, skill development, career discovery, recruitment, or access to opportunities.

### 2. Healthcare

Explore AI solutions that can support healthcare accessibility, administration, information, wellness, or patient experiences.

### **3. Business Productivity**

Build AI tools that help individuals, startups, SMEs, and organizations improve productivity, automate processes, or make better decisions.

### **4. Finance**

Develop AI solutions related to financial accessibility, financial literacy, business finance, personal finance, or financial technology.

### **5. Sustainability and Climate**

Use AI to address environmental challenges, resource efficiency, climate action, sustainability, or responsible consumption.

### **6. Smart Cities**

Create solutions that improve transportation, public services, urban experiences, safety, accessibility, or city operations.

### **7. Agriculture and Food**

Explore how AI can support agriculture, food systems, farmers, supply chains, or food security.

### **8. Tourism**

Build AI solutions that improve travel planning, tourism experiences, accessibility, cultural discovery, or tourism operations.

### **9. Accessibility and Social Impact**

Use AI to address challenges faced by underserved communities and create technology that improves inclusion and access.

### **10. Open Innovation**

Participants may work on any other meaningful problem where AI can create clear real world impact.

### 3. Build During the Ideathon

- The **core project must be developed during the official AI Ideathon 2026 period.**
- Participants may use open source libraries, APIs, AI models, frameworks, development platforms, and publicly available resources.
- Participants may use AI coding assistants and generative AI tools during development.
- Previously created projects may not be submitted as new AI Ideathon projects.
- Existing libraries, reusable components, frameworks, templates, APIs, and open source packages may be used, but the core solution submitted for judging must be created during the event.
- Every team should be able to clearly explain what was created during AI Ideathon 2026.
- Organizers and judges may request supporting evidence, including repositories, commit history, prototypes, or development records.

### 4. Tools and Sponsor Resources

Participants are free to use **any AI models, development tools, frameworks, APIs, platforms, or technologies** they prefer.

Participants may also receive access to resources, credits, or tools provided by AI Ideathon partners and sponsors.

Participants are encouraged to experiment with sponsor technologies, but **using sponsor tools is optional unless specifically stated for a sponsor award or challenge.**

No advanced coding experience is required.

Participants may use traditional development, AI assisted development, no code platforms, low code platforms, or a combination of different approaches.

Projects will be judged based on the quality of the solution rather than the number of technologies used.

### 5. Submission Process

Each team must submit its project before the official submission deadline announced by the organizers.

Only **one submission per team** should be made.

The final submission may require:

- Team name and member information
- Project name
- Problem statement
- Solution description
- Target users
- Technologies and AI tools used
- Prototype or demo link
- Source code or GitHub repository
- Presentation materials
- Video pitch
- Additional information requested by the organizers

Late submissions may not be accepted.

Participants are responsible for confirming that all submitted links and files are accessible to the judging team.

## 7. Video Pitch

Each team must submit a **3 minute video pitch** presenting its project.

The video should clearly explain:

### 1. The Problem

What problem are you solving, and who experiences it?

### 2. The Solution

What have you built, and how does AI contribute to the solution?

### 3. The Prototype

Demonstrate the main functionality of your project.

### 4. The Impact

Explain the potential value and real world impact of the solution.

### 5. The Future

Briefly explain how the project could develop beyond the ideathon.

All eligible submissions will be reviewed by the judging panel.

Based on the initial evaluation, the **Top 10 teams** will advance to the Final Pitch Round.

## 8. Final Live Pitch

The **Top 15 finalist teams** will present their projects live to the judging panel.

Each finalist team will receive an allocated presentation period consisting of:

- **4 minute live pitch**
- **2 to 3 minute question and answer session** with the judges

Teams should be prepared to demonstrate their prototype during the presentation.

If a live demonstration is not possible because of an unexpected technical problem, teams should have a recorded demonstration available as backup.

Following the presentations, judges will complete their final evaluation and determine the winners.

## 9. Judging Criteria

Projects will be evaluated according to the following criteria:

### 1. Problem Fit and Real World Impact, 25%

- Is the problem clearly defined?
- Is the problem meaningful for the intended users?
- Does the solution address a genuine real world need?
- Could the solution create measurable value or impact?

### 2. Innovation and Idea Quality, 20%

- Is the idea creative?
- Does the solution provide a meaningful improvement over existing approaches?
- Is AI being used purposefully rather than simply added to the project?

### 3. Technical Implementation, 20%

- Has the team developed a functional prototype or convincing technical concept?

- Does the AI functionality work as described?
- Is the technical approach logical and feasible?
- Can the team clearly explain how the system works?

#### **4. Product Potential and Scalability, 20%**

- Could the solution develop into a usable product, startup, or scalable initiative?
- Is there a clearly identifiable target user or customer?
- Can the solution grow beyond the hackathon?
- Is there potential for adoption, commercialization, partnership, or future funding?

#### **5. Demo and Presentation, 15%**

- Is the problem communicated clearly?
- Is the proposed solution easy to understand?
- Does the demonstration effectively show the project's main functionality?
- Can the team communicate its value within the allocated presentation time?

## **10. Fair Participation**

The following actions are prohibited:

- Plagiarizing or copying another team's work.
- Submitting a project primarily developed before AI Ideathon 2026.
- Presenting someone else's code, design, research, or intellectual property as your own.
- Misrepresenting the functionality of a prototype.
- Misrepresenting the use of AI within the project.
- Providing false information about team members or project development.
- Interfering with another team's work or submission.
- Attempting to manipulate the judging or voting process.
- Refusing to provide reasonable evidence of project development when requested by the judging panel.

The organizers may request access to a project's source code, repository, development history, or other relevant materials to verify eligibility.

Projects found violating these rules may be **disqualified**.

## 12. Intellectual Property and Project Ownership

Teams **retain ownership of the projects they create during AI Ideathon 2026**.

Participation does not transfer ownership of a project to Cognisor AI, event organizers, sponsors, mentors, judges, or community partners.

Participants are responsible for ensuring that the technologies, datasets, APIs, media, and other materials they use comply with applicable licenses and usage terms.

By participating, teams grant the organizers permission to feature their:

- Team name
- Participant names
- Project name
- Project description
- Screenshots
- Demo materials
- Pitch recordings
- Event photographs or recordings

on event websites, social media, community channels, reports, promotional materials, and future AI Ideathon communications.

## 14. Code of Conduct

All participants are expected to maintain a respectful, inclusive, professional, and collaborative environment throughout AI Ideathon 2026.

Participants must:

- Treat participants, mentors, judges, speakers, sponsors, and organizers respectfully.
- Avoid harassment, discrimination, intimidation, or abusive behavior.
- Communicate professionally in Discord, Zoom, and other official event platforms.
- Avoid spam, inappropriate promotion, or disruptive behavior.

- Respect the privacy and intellectual property of other participants.
- Follow instructions provided by the organizing team.
- Use official event channels responsibly.

The organizers reserve the right to remove or **disqualify participants** who violate the Code of Conduct.

## 15. Online Event Requirements

AI Ideathon 2026 is conducted online.

Participants are responsible for:

- Having access to a computer suitable for development.
- Maintaining a stable internet connection where possible.
- Creating any accounts required for the tools they choose to use.
- Configuring their own development environment.
- Joining official sessions through the links provided by organizers.
- Monitoring Discord and other official communication channels for announcements.
- Ensuring their microphone, camera, screen sharing, and presentation setup work before the Final Pitch Round.

Technical problems on a participant's side do not automatically extend submission or presentation deadlines.

Teams are strongly encouraged to maintain backups of their code, presentation, and prototype demonstration.

## 16. Communication and Discord

Discord will serve as one of the primary communication platforms for AI Ideathon 2026.

Participants should complete the required Discord onboarding questions to receive access to the appropriate AI Ideathon channels.

Participants are responsible for monitoring official announcements during the event.



## 17. Organizer Decisions

The organizing team reserves the right to make reasonable adjustments to schedules, judging procedures, submission requirements, awards, or event operations when necessary.

Any important changes will be communicated through official AI Ideathon channels.

Decisions regarding eligibility, rule violations, finalist selection, judging, and disqualification will be made by the organizers and judging panel.

Judging decisions are final.

## Project Submission Guidelines

All teams participating in **AI Ideathon 2026** must submit their final project through the official Cognisor AI hackathon platform.

**Official Submission Platform:**

<https://impacthackathons.cognisorai.com/>

**Submission Deadline:**

**14 August 2026, 7:00 PM JST**

The latest successfully saved version of your project before the deadline will be used for judging.

## 1. Create Your Participant Account

Visit the official platform:

<https://impacthackathons.cognisorai.com/>

Create a **Participant** account and sign in using Google.

Use the email address you want the organizers and judges to associate with your participation.

New participants must complete the onboarding process before accessing the participant dashboard.

During onboarding:

1. Select **AI Ideathon 2026** as your event.
2. Enter your full name.
3. Select your role, such as Engineer, Designer, Product, Domain Expert, Founder, or Other.
4. Skills and social profiles are optional.

## 2. Confirm AI Ideathon 2026

After signing in, open **My Hackathons** from your participant dashboard.

Make sure **AI Ideathon 2026** is selected before creating or editing your submission.

If you have joined multiple events, use the hackathon switcher to select the correct event.

Your project is connected to the event currently selected in your dashboard, so check this carefully before saving.

## 3. Open My Project

From your participant dashboard, select:

### My Project

The official submission form contains **three main steps**:

**Step 1:** Project Details

**Step 2:** Team Details

**Step 3:** Links and Media

Complete all required information before your final save.

## Step 1: Project Details

### Project Title

Enter the official name of your project exactly as you want judges to see it.

Keep the title clear, professional, and easy to remember.

### Project URL

Provide a working link to your project.

This can be:

- Live product or prototype
- GitHub repository
- Public product page
- Other accessible project link

Judges must be able to open the link without requesting permission or access.

## Short Description

Write a concise explanation covering:

- The problem you identified
- Your solution
- Who the solution helps
- How AI is used

The short description must contain **at least 40 characters**.

## Step 2: Team Details

### Team Name

Enter your official AI Ideathon team name.

### Member Names

Enter every person who contributed to the project.

Use **one member name per line**.

The names should match the actual participants who built the project.

### Team Invite Link

The person who first saves the project becomes the **submission owner**.

After the first save:

1. Click **Save Submission**.
2. Select **Create invite link**.
3. Copy the generated team invitation link.
4. Send it to your teammates.
5. Each teammate signs in using their participant account.
6. Each teammate accepts the invitation.

This connects your teammates to the same official project submission.

Do not create separate project submissions for individual team members.

**One team should have one official submission.**

## Step 3: Links and Media

### Project Cover

Upload a cover image representing your project.

**Recommended size:** 1600 × 900 pixels

Accepted image formats include:

JPG

PNG

WebP

GIF

Maximum file size is **5 MB**.

### Project Gallery

You may upload up to **12 images**.

These can include:

- Product screenshots
- Interface screens
- Demo screenshots
- Architecture visuals
- Prototype images
- Team photos

Use this section to help judges quickly understand what you built.

### Submission PDF URL

This is a **public URL**, not a direct PDF upload.

Upload your submission document to a service such as Google Drive, Dropbox, or another publicly accessible platform.

Then paste the public link into the Submission PDF URL field.

For Google Drive, make sure access is set so that **anyone with the link can view**.

Judges should not need to request access.

## **What Should Be in the Submission PDF?**

Your PDF should allow a judge to understand and evaluate the project even without a live explanation.

Include:

### **1. Problem**

What real world problem are you solving?

Who experiences this problem?

Why does it matter?

### **2. Solution**

What did you build?

How does your solution address the problem?

### **3. AI Implementation**

Explain how AI is actually used.

Mention relevant:

- Models
- APIs
- Agents
- Data
- Automation
- AI workflows
- Limitations

## 4. Product and Technical Approach

Explain how your prototype works and the technologies used to build it.

## 5. User Experience

Show how someone would actually use your product.

## 6. Responsible AI

Where relevant, explain considerations around privacy, security, bias, transparency, safety, or human oversight.

## 7. Current Prototype

Clearly distinguish between:

**What currently works**

and

**What you plan to build later**

## 8. Impact and Future Potential

Explain how the solution could grow, create impact, reach more users, or potentially become a sustainable product or startup.

# Demo Video

A **public demo video URL** must be provided.

The demo should show your actual working prototype rather than only presentation slides.

You may use YouTube or another publicly accessible video platform.

Your video should demonstrate:

- The problem
- Your solution
- Main product experience
- Core functionality
- AI implementation

- Working prototype

Keep the video short and focused.

Before submission, open the video link in a private browser window to confirm that judges can access it.

The portal provides a video preview. If the preview does not work, check the URL and its privacy settings.

## Complete Submission Requirements

For AI Ideathon 2026, your submission should not be considered complete until it contains:

1. **Project Title**
2. **Short Description**, minimum 40 characters
3. **Working Project URL**
4. **Team Name**
5. **All Team Member Names**
6. **Public Submission PDF URL**
7. **Public Demo Video URL**
8. **Project Cover Image**
9. **Working public permissions for every submitted link**

The core judging package consists of your project title, description, project URL, PDF, and demo video.

## Public Project Gallery

The platform also gives you the option to make your project publicly visible.

Look for:

**Show this project on hackathon boards and the public Projects & demos gallery**

This option is **not required for judging**.

If selected, your project information can appear publicly on the event board and project gallery.

Your scores and private judge notes will remain private.

If you do not select it, organizers and judges can still access and evaluate your submission.

## Save Your Submission

This is one of the most important steps.

After completing your project:

1. Review every field.
2. Test every URL.
3. Click **Save Submission**.
4. Wait until you see:

**Submission saved successfully.**

Do not close the page before receiving confirmation.

The platform may save drafts while you work, but **autosave does not replace the official Save Submission action**.

## You Can Update Before the Deadline

You may continue improving and updating the same submission while submissions remain open.

Judges will evaluate the **latest successfully saved version**.

After making any changes, click **Save Submission** again.

Do not create a new project every time you make an update.

## Submission Deadline

**14 August 2026**

**7:00 PM JST**

All final submissions must be successfully saved through:

<https://impacthackathons.cognisorai.com/>

**Submit early.**

Do not wait until 6:59 PM JST.

Deployment issues, video processing, internet problems, incorrect Google Drive permissions, broken links, or upload errors will not change the official deadline.



The final successfully saved submission before the deadline is the version considered for judging.

## Before You Submit

Check your project from an **incognito or private browser window**.

Make sure:

- Project URL opens
- Demo works
- PDF opens
- Video plays
- No permission request appears
- Images display correctly
- Repository is accessible where applicable
- No API keys or passwords are exposed

All submitted links must be accessible to judges without requesting permission.

## Important Rules

- Portal submission is mandatory.
- A GitHub repository alone is not an official submission.
- A Google Drive folder alone is not an official submission.
- Registration for the hackathon does not automatically submit your project.
- One team should submit one official project.
- Team names and member names must accurately represent the people who built the project.
- All links must be accessible to judges.
- Never expose API keys, passwords, private datasets, tokens, or credentials.
- The public gallery is optional.

- The latest successful save before the deadline is the version used for judging.

## Final Submission Checklist

- I am signed in using my participant account.
- AI Ideathon 2026 is selected as my event.
- My project title is final.
- My description clearly explains the problem, solution, impact, and AI usage.
- My description contains at least 40 characters.
- My project URL works.
- My team name is correct.
- Every team member is listed.
- My teammates have joined the submission where applicable.
- My project cover is uploaded.
- My Submission PDF URL works.
- My demo video is public and playable.
- My submitted links work in an incognito browser.
- My project does not expose passwords, API keys, or credentials.
- I clicked Save Submission.
- I received the successful save confirmation.
- My final version was saved before 14 August 2026 at 7:00 PM JST.

## Need Help?

If you experience a submission issue, contact the AI Ideathon organizing team through the official participant support channel as soon as possible.

When reporting an issue, provide:

**Team Name**

**Team Leader Name**

**Registered Email**

**Screenshot of the Issue**

**Short Description of the Problem**

## Official Submission Platform

<https://impacthackathons.cognisorai.com/>

**Deadline: 14 August 2026, 7:00 PM JST**

**Build. Test. Review. Save. Submit early.**